

WHY INDIA SHOULD WORRY

A splintering Pakistan with loose nukes is a nightmarish scenario for New Delhi, and the world

The worsening situation in Pakistan and the near collapse of government control has been a cause of concern for India. There are warnings that Pakistan-based groups are planning to mount attacks similar to the 26/11-terror attack. "There is total confusion in Pakistan and I don't think there is any effective government functioning there," says External Affairs Minister S.M. Krishna. Apart from a rising spiral of terrorism emanating from Pakistan against India, there is concern about the country spinning out of control and its nukes falling into militant hands. Besides, an unstable Pakistan impedes India's economic goals and retards its ambition of playing a larger role in the international arena as it is bogged down by troubles in its backyard.

Even as concern is mounting at the prospect of an imploding Pakistan and its effect on India, there is also a change of gears in the Indian strategy. What is evolving as a new way of dealing with the threat from Pakistan is a three-pillar approach, with a clear role for three frontline ministries—External Affairs, Home and Defence. While the External Affairs Ministry is managing the diplomatic fallout and is engaging with the US, the other two ministries are meeting the operational ends. "The idea is to keep sustained pressure on, while diplomatically tackling Pakistan through international interlocutors and through friends and allies," explains a senior South Block official.

"We are increasingly vigilant on the terror threats from across the border," said Foreign Secretary Nirupama Rao. On the diplomatic front, a clear message is being sent that in the absence of any concrete steps by Pakistan, India will not resume the composite dialogue process, even though interaction on the sidelines of multilateral events will go on. For instance, a meeting with Prime Minister Manmohan Singh and his Pakistani counterpart on the sidelines of the CHOGM Summit in Trinidad is on the cards, but the focus is on flagging India's concerns on terrorism. Besides, in the meetings with US interlocutors in the run-up to the Prime Minister's summit with Obama on November 24, India will now insist that the compartment approach in dealing with terror groups and their affiliates is

actually hurting effective action against terrorists.

The other part of this strategy is being steered by Home Minister P. Chidambaram and the integrated security setup which has embarked on a programme on investing heavily in beefing up the security infrastructure along the border and on the Line of Control. Part of this strategy is also to get better intelligence and develop levers within Pakistan to provide information on terror groups and their movements in coordination with other friendly agencies.

Besides, the new strategy also has to factor in the new threats. According to latest intelligence inputs, the new strategy by Pakistan-based militant groups is to recruit foreign militants and harness radical institutions in the US and Europe to source cadres for attacks. The recent

example is of the two suspected LeT operatives, David Coleman Headley and Tahawwur Hussain Rana, arrested by the US Federal Bureau of Investigation (FBI). The two men were in touch with the Pakistani Consul-General in Chicago and, according to the FBI, were planning attacks on key targets in Delhi and Denmark. Pakistan clearly is on the defensive but instead of owning responsibility and taking action against terror groups including the 26/11 accused, it has now

embarked on a game of diplomatic deflection, accusing India of funding the Taliban and terror groups in South Waziristan, a charge which India has rubbished.

Faced with a belligerent neighbour, the third pillar of this strategy is to develop covert capabilities of striking at terror groups and, in case of a terror attack, an effective response that would combine precision strikes, which can be sandwiched with a diplomatic cool-down approach. While India has to brace for newer threats emerging out of the matrix of terrorism in Pakistan, the key will be to weave multinational cooperation to take on these threats. By encouraging greater cooperation between the intelligence agencies and helping develop leads and actionable intelligence, these terror threats can be tackled, and India would have to continue reinforcing the message through diplomacy that the terror threats emerging from Pakistan are no longer just India's migraine but pose grave danger to democracies around the world.

by Saurabh Shukla



INTERNATIONAL MEETS ARE USED TO FLAG INDIA'S CONCERNS ON TERRORISM